

Introduction

SmartScale is a practical, mobile-first AI training programme designed to equip entrepreneurs, startups, and SMEs in Ghana and Nigeria with the skills needed to use AI to grow and streamline their businesses. An initiative by The Pitch Hub, *SmartScale* focuses on simple, accessible tools that entrepreneurs can use immediately, often right from their phones to create content, automate customer service, improve operations, and increase sales.

The Problem

Small businesses across Ghana and Nigeria operate under intense pressure with competing priorities, limited budgets, and the high cost of hiring skilled talent. Many founders struggle to keep up with marketing, customer service, and operations while trying to grow sustainably.

This challenge contributes to high failure rates: up to 80% of African startups fail within the first five years, often due to operational inefficiencies, limited technical capacity, and resource constraints.

Despite the rising global adoption of AI, many African entrepreneurs have not yet leveraged its potential. Not because AI isn't relevant, but because they have not had the opportunity to explore how simple, accessible tools can support their daily business activities.

This creates a growing digital divide where entrepreneurs risk being left behind as global markets accelerate with AI.

The Opportunity

There is a clear and urgent opportunity to support AI adoption among African SMEs.

Africa's AI market is projected to reach USD 4.51 billion by 2025, growing to USD 16.53 billion by 2030 (Mastercard, 2025). Despite this rapid growth, AI adoption among African SMEs remains low, mainly due to limited skills and lack of practical

exposure to accessible tools (Journal of International Scientific Research & Analysis, 2025).

At the same time, 47% of business leaders in the Middle East & Africa report that they are already using or eager to adopt AI to drive competitiveness (HLB Global Business Leaders Survey, 2024). This shows strong regional momentum — yet small businesses still lag behind.

This gap between potential and adoption signals a major opportunity: entrepreneurs need simple, hands-on guidance to understand how AI can support their daily business activities.

Our Solution: *SmartScale*

SmartScale directly addresses this gap by providing a hands-on, approachable AI programme designed specifically for African business owners.

SmartScale contributes to the following UN Sustainable Development Goals:

- SDG 4 – Quality Education: delivering practical digital and AI skills.
- SDG 8 – Decent Work & Economic Growth: equipping entrepreneurs to increase productivity and revenue.
- SDG 9 – Industry, Innovation & Infrastructure: promoting digital adoption and innovation within SMEs.

Programme Format

- 4 Days Total
- 2 Days Virtual (training + practice)
- 1 Day In-Person (implementation lab in Accra & Lagos)

Proposed dates

	Type	Location	Date
Session 1	Virtual	Online	6th Dec, 2025
Session 2	Virtual	Online	12th Dec, 2025
Session 3	In-person	Ghana	29th Dec, 2025
Session 4	In-person	Nigeria	10 Jan, 2026 (tbc)

What Participants Will Learn

By the end of SMARTSCALE, participants will:

- Understand AI clearly and confidently
- Use 6–7 essential, beginner-friendly AI tools
- Create marketing and admin assets
- Automate key business tasks
- Improve customer response time
- Save 3–5 hours of work each week
- Build simple dashboards and admin tools
- Apply AI to reduce workload and increase revenue
- Develop a clear 90-day AI plan

What Participants Will Walk Away With

- Two completed business assets (e.g., content calendar, flyer, video, dashboard)
- One working automation (e.g., WhatsApp quick replies)
- A personalised AI starter toolkit
- A 90-day AI adoption plan

Programme Breakdown

Session 1 – Virtual (2 Hours)

Participants learn essential, easy-to-use AI tools for marketing, communication, customer service, and admin.

Session 2 – Virtual (2 Hours)

Participants choose a track (Marketing, Customer Service, Admin/Finance) and build practical assets.

Session 3 – In-Person (4-5 Hours) (One in Accra, one in Lagos)

Participants complete two outputs—one primary and one quick win—and develop a 90-day plan.

Why SmartScale Matters Now

SmartScale arrives at a critical moment when entrepreneurs urgently need support adopting AI but lack practical, accessible training. By keeping the tools simple, mobile-friendly, and implementation-focused, SmartScale bridges the digital skills gap and empowers African entrepreneurs to compete in the AI era.

About The Pitch Hub

The Pitch Hub is a capacity-building and entrepreneurship development organisation focused on equipping African founders and SMEs with the tools, skills, and strategies to grow sustainably. Through training, storytelling, coaching, and community-building, The Pitch Hub has supported thousands of entrepreneurs across Africa. SmartScale is an extension of our mission to help entrepreneurs leverage emerging technologies to scale faster and more effectively.

Conclusion

SmartScale offers a timely, relevant, and impactful solution for entrepreneurs who want to use AI to boost productivity, improve marketing, and grow their businesses. It fills a critical gap by providing practical, easy-to-implement AI skills tailored to the realities of African entrepreneurs.